

SWC Hoop Tourney Very Tough to Pick

This is the biggest weekend of the season in Texas basketball. The best Southwest Conference teams are at The Summit in Houston to decide which will survive to battle for the nation's top honors in the NCAA playoffs. And in Austin, five state high school boys' champions will be crowned at the Super Drum.

Texas and Arkansas are SWC co-champs but that doesn't mean one of them will emerge a winner in the post-season tournament, which has been a huge success in its three years. They also shared the title in 1978 but Houston beat them both to be the league representative in the NCAA playoffs. Arkansas also got to the playoffs via an at-large berth. There is no favorite. You can never count anybody out in basketball, and especially this year.

Baylor, which tied for fourth with Texas Tech, and sixth-place Houston tangle in the second game of the tournament tonight. Third-place Texas A&M, which won a bye, takes on Tech in the opener. The Baylor-Houston winner faces Texas in the semifinals Friday. A&M or Tech will square off with Arkansas that same night. The tournament champion and SWC play-off delegate will be decided Saturday night. There hasn't been an unsold seat in the house for weeks.

THE STATE HIGH SCHOOL tournament is 59 years old. El Paso, led by Andy Cohen, was the first champion in 1921, defeating San Antonio, 25-11. Cohen later gained fame as a big league baseball player after a stop at shortstop for the Waco Cubs of the Texas League. All schools were in the same class in high school basketball until 1942, when they were classified B, A and AA according to enrollment. Champions were Sidell in class B, Van in class A and Houston Jefferson Davis in class AA. Major Keithly's Waco Tigers lost to Jeff Davis in the first round of the state tournament.

The current arrangement — classes B, A, AA, AAA and AAAA — began in 1953. Cayuga, White Oak, Bowie, Beaumont South Park and Pampa were champions. Pampa has won the most Class AAAA crowns — four. Austin has been in the state tournament the most times — 20 — but has never been state champ. The 1928 team beat Bill Henderson's Temple Wildcats in the finals but was disqualified because of an ineligible player. Waco has played in 12 tournaments, 10 under Keithly, with the same luck as Austin. San Antonio Lanier has played in 11 and won two Class AAA titles, the same number as San Antonio Alamo Heights and Houston Smiley.

Athens made eight appearances and won five times, also winning a national title under coach Jimmy Kitts with the Tompkins brothers, Reynolds brothers, Buster Brannon and Doc Sumner. Buna was champ seven times in both A and AA. Snook is bidding for its fourth crown this year, winning in both B and A.

Play begins at 8:30 a.m. today in Class B with Krum meeting West Lamar followed by Snook and



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Whitharral. Krum, undefeated in 43 games, is defending champ. Snook was class A winner last year. Lanier, this year's Austin representative with a 33-3 record, plays Fort Worth Dunbar (35-3) Friday. Five champions will be crowned Saturday. Houston Madison with a perfect 39-0 record is top ranked in AAAA.

THE GIRLS ARE CARRYING on for our neck of the woods. Richfield, which has mopped up on 35 opponents without a loss, seeks a state tournament spot in the Region II-AAAA tournament at College Station against Duncanville. Robinson, state champion in 1970, bids for another Austin trip in the Region III-AA tournament at Brenham. Suzie Eppers' Rockettes romped into the regional by 18 points.

TEN AGING free agents hit a \$15-million jackpot from baseball owners in this year's draft. Owners committed themselves to a total of \$15,602,000 compared to \$21,315,249 they spent on last year's 10. But the average age of 1978's millionaires was 28.2; this year the average is 32.3. Two years ago owners forced million-dollar deals on 14 unsuspecting players (at a cost of \$23,952,000) whose average age was 28.5.

Pete Rose, 38, led the parade this year with a 4-year, \$2,980,000 pact with Philadelphia. Rico Carty is the oldest of the crowd at 39. Toronto retained his services for five years at a partially-guaranteed \$1.1-million pact. His contract is also the longest in length — 31 pages.

Other decrepit millionaires are Jim Slaton, 28, Milwaukee, six years, \$1,460,000; Darrell Evans, 31, San Francisco, five years, \$1,435,000; Tommy John, 35, Yankees, three years, \$1,417,000; Mike Marshall, 35, Minnesota, four years, \$1,350,000; Larry Gura, 31, Kansas City, five years, \$1,325,000; Elias Sosa, 28, five years, Montreal, \$1,220,000; Lee Lacy, 29, Pittsburgh, six years, \$1,050,000; and Jim Barr, 30, California, four years, \$1,010,000.

Prices on others ranged from Luis Tiant's two years with the Yankees at \$740,000 to Willie Horton's \$36,500 for one year at Seattle. This is the last time around for some of the old folks.

Yankee manager Bob Lemon has so many pitchers he doesn't know what to do. He must make up his mind among such as Cy Young winner Ron Guidry, Ed Figueroa, Tommy John, Luis Tiant, Paul Mirabella, Catfish Hunter, Jim Beattie and Ken Clay. Mirabella, part of the deal with the Texas Rangers for Sparky Lyle, seems like a bonanza. But injuries last year proved you can never have too much pitching.